

# The changing Moon

The Moon orbits the Earth as the Earth orbits the Sun. We can see the Moon most nights and often during the day, too. However, the Moon we see seems to change shape in a 29.5-day cycle. The different shapes of the Moon we see are called its phases.

## Moon views

As the Moon orbits the Earth, our view of it changes as the Sun lights up more or less of the side we see. At times, it seems to disappear altogether.

**New Moon**—we cannot see it because none of the side that faces us is lit up.



**Crescent**—it will soon disappear again.



**Last quarter**—it is on the last quarter of its orbit.



← The Sun lights up the Moon and the Earth.

**Crescent**—the Sun begins to light up our side of the Moon.



**First quarter**—it has moved around the first quarter of its orbit.

